CHAPTER 11

T H E P E O P L E S

MAJOR GROUPS

The two major groups of the population of Palestine, according to national allegiance, are Arabs and Jews. At the end of 1944, only about 2 percent (34,000) of the people permanently resident in the country were persons outside these two national groups. About 66 percent (1,185,000) of the total population was Arab, and about 32 percent (565,000) was Jewish.

According to religion, about 90 percent of the Arab population is Moslem, about 9 percent Christian and about 1 percent Druse. The Jews by nationality generally profess a more or less orthodox Jewish faith; a considerable number however have no religious affiliation, and a handful are christian. The persons of neither Arab nor Jewish nationality are almost all Christian.

The Moslems of Palestine, with insignificant exceptions, speak Arabic as their mother tongue and are Arab in national sentiment. Three-quarters of the Christians also speak Arabic as their mother tongue and may also be regarded as Arab in national sentiment, though not so unequivocally as the Moslem Arabs: an undertone of fear of religious persecution inhibits full national cooperation of Christian Arabs with Moslem Arabs. In addition to the religious cleavage, there is an economic and cultural one deriving from the fact that the Christian Arabs of Palestine are about three-quarters an urban people, while the Moslems are little more than one-quarter urban. Christian Arab villages and towns are generally better developed, cleaner, and have more non-Arab elements than Moslem villages and towns. The great Arab families of Palestine -- such as the Husseinis, the Nashashibis, the Tuqans -- are all Moslem. When a Christian Arab looks for a strong point of support, he is likely to look outside the Arab community.